BRINGING THE WORLD TO GOA

The sunshine state's Minister for Tourism & Information Technology **ROHAN ASHOK KHAUNTE** discusses plans for boosting infrastructure, inclusivity and facilities for travellers in Goa's near future

With the inauguration of the international airport at Mopa which new international markets is Goa Tourism exploring?

The Manohar International Airport at Mopa provides us with excellent opportunities for further outreach into international markets. We are going to focus on key markets such as West Europe, the UK, France, Germany, Spain and are also looking enthusiastically at the Middle East especially the UAE and nearby countries. We are focussing on South East Asia and markets like Australia, New Zealand, Japan and South Korea. This will help us diversify our product portfolio and will ensure that we are not too over-dependent on one or two markets like Russia and the UK. We have recently seen that when (reliance on a few markets) financial and geo-political turmoil sets in, really affects the International visitor profile to our beautiful state. Hence it is in our best interest to always look for new markets, develop them and diversify our portfolio so that we are well-hedged as and when the international tourist arrival situation turns green. I am optimistic that Goa has a lot to offer to international tourists especially our rich heritage and culture. We are going to focus on these aspects to make Goa a year-round destination.

How has Goa Tourism contributed to the Ease of doing business? Please shed some light on the new legislation introduced.

The Goa government believes in easing up several procedures and making it easy for trade members to register their properties and other businesses under the tourist trade act. Recently, we have introduced a notification to reduce the paperwork to enable trade members to easily register properties and trade with the tourism department to curb the illegalities. I have decided to come down heavily on all illegalities such as non-registered villas, bungalows, non-registered hotels, water sports operators, and touts, all of whom bring a bad name to the state. We are in the process of constituting a flying squad which will take immediate action once the illegalities are noticed. Regarding new legislations, Goa Tourism has tied up with NALSAR University to draft progressive legislation to meet the challenges posed by evolution in tourism. We are focusing on the development of the Goa Tourism Board and will be recruiting professionals to play an ever-increasing role in the smooth management of the Board. We will focus on a Tourism Master Plan and policy which has been recently adopted by the state government. We are going to ensure that the state develops holistically and in a sustainable manner as a responsible tourism destination.

Tell us more about the 'Tourism Awareness on Safety & Security' for Goa's 10 million visitors?

Goa is one of the safest travel destinations in the world. We have an integrated system of beach safety with 500 lifeguards and night police patrol on our beaches. We also have a very active tourist force.

In addition, there is a network of CCTV cameras which we propose to set up at key locations. There is also a proposal to set up devices which will collect statistics at important tourist places. With this, we expect that security for tourists will improve.

Similarly, we are increasing the fleet for effective patrolling on all beaches. There will be new vehicles and we will introduce a policy for integrated beach safety management to promote the image of Goa as a safe tourism destination.

You have been promoting Software as the addition to 'Sun, Sand and Sea', with the concept of workations. Please comment.

After the pandemic, the travelling world has undergone a sea change. More young people prefer to travel as digital nomads outside the confines of office spaces. Countries have started issuing digital nomad visas.

It is an increasing trend to be a global citizen, working from anywhere and enjoying your work as you explore new places on this planet. Goa shouldn't be left behind.

We have begun putting the basic infrastructure in place to support 'workations' on all our beaches. We encourage the private sector to set up their own workation spaces in restaurants and cafeterias so that along with improved connectivity, Goa will be a preferred destination for young digital nomads.

We are also taking lots of steps in IT to attract talent and companies to set up their base here and this is all expected to improve the tourist flow into the state, especially in the premium category.

One of your priorities has been comprehensive beach cleaning management.

There is no doubt that clean beaches attract good quality tourists. We will take every effort to ensure that Goa's beaches are kept clean. We are also working on blue flag beach certification commencing with the beautiful beaches in Canacona.



We are revamping the existing beach cleaning system and increasing the number of shifts from one to two so that beaches are always clean.

There will also be special provisions for people with disabilities with special ramps and wheelchair arrangements so that our beaches can welcome all people.

How will the resumption of e-visas for British nationals affect the industry?

We welcome the recent decision of the government to resume e-visa facilities for our friends from the United Kingdom. This is undoubtedly expected to boost the number of tourists to Goa and India.

With Mopa airport, we can expect direct connectivity from the UK which will bring in more visitors. Goa is a very popular destination for British tourists. We are also awaiting the announcement and opening of e-visa facilities after the pandemic to other countries especially Commonwealth countries such as Uzbekistan and Tajikistan which have a lot of potential because tourists from these countries are now travelling abroad in large numbers.

While Russia remains a strong traditional market, there is a great potential to attract tourists from countries such as Georgia, Armenia, the Baltic states like Latvia, Lithuania, Eastern Europe, Poland, Czech Republic. With the improvement in connectivity, I am sure we will take up this option, and e-visa facilities to these nationals will further boost arrivals in the state.